

Politics of Survival

A game of collaboration, deception, and diplomacy at the end of the world

A giant asteroid will strike Earth in five years. The only hope for humanity is leaving on a colony ship — one that no nation can build alone. You and your rival must cooperate to build it. But whoever dominates the ship's new political order will rule what remains of humanity. Cooperate too little and everyone dies. Concede too much and you'll survive, but under the domination of your rival superpower.



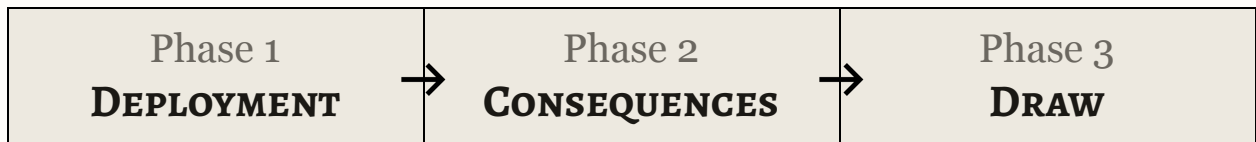
Objective

Work with your rival to complete the colony ship — while outmaneuvering them for political dominance. At the end of five years, whoever controls more of the ship's modules wins. But first, the ship must be ready to launch. Fail that, and you both lose.

Setup

1. Place five six-sided dice on the table. Each die represents one module of the ship. Roll all five. Each die's value is that module's starting development level.
2. *New players may remove special cards for a simpler first game.*
3. Shuffle the deck and deal 8 cards to each player. The deck is your draw pile.
4. The game lasts 5 rounds. Begin.

Each Round



DEPLOYMENT. Players can talk, declare deployment plans, negotiate, bluff. Then each player places one card face-down on every module simultaneously. Cards are not revealed yet.

CONSEQUENCES. For each module (left to right), flip and resolve the deployed cards. Update the module's development level (*turn the die*) and player influence (*add/remove influence tokens*).

DRAW. Discard the deployed cards into the discard pile. Each player draws back up to 8 cards. When you run out of cards, reshuffle the discard pile into a new draw pile. Begin the next round.

Next to each module, keep track of influence with tokens.

Tokens in either player's color should show who is ahead in influence by how much.

The total influence of each player does not matter, only the difference in influence matters.

The Main Cards

Engineers

Module development increases by 1.

Colonists

Your influence increases by 1.

Military

Your influence increases by 2.

If deployed vs another Military, module development decreases by 1.

The dilemma: Both players need the modules to develop, but that means giving up chances to get ahead in influence. Too much greed, on the other hand, can destroy all their progress.

Engineers vs Engineers. Module level increases by two, neither side gets ahead in influence.
Ultimate selfless cooperation to get the ship closer to a successful launch.

Colonists vs Engineers. Module level increases by 1, Player 1's influence gets ahead by 1.

Colonists vs Colonists. Module level stays the same, neither side gets ahead in influence.

Military vs Engineers. Module level increases by 1, Player 1's influence gets ahead by 2.
Player 1 is exploiting Player 2, taking a huge leap in influence as Player 2 works on the ship.

Military vs Colonists. Module level stays the same, Player 1's influence gets ahead by 1.

Military vs Military. Module level drops by 2, neither side gets an influence.
Oh no! Rising tensions between the two militaries cause incidents that set development levels back! Greedy risk-taking by both players sets the survival project back by years.

End of the Game

After Round 5, the game ends. First, check if the ship can fly.

Launch condition: At least four of the five modules need to be at level 5 or 6. If not, the ship cannot launch before the asteroid hits, and **both players lose**. Humanity goes extinct.

If the ship launches, determine the winner by module control. For each module, the player ahead in influence wins that module. Equal influence means the module is neutral. If a module was not ready for launch at the end, it is left behind and does not count towards victory.

- **The player controlling most modules wins the game.**
Political dominance. One power holds more sway over humanity and sets the terms of the voyage.
- **If both players control the same number of modules, the game ends in a draw.**
Stalemate. An uneasy equilibrium is reached between superpowers. A fragile balance holds for now.
- **If the ship fails to launch, there are no winners.**
Catastrophe. Perhaps a fitting end to a greedy species that failed to cooperate.



A pitiful post-apocalyptic end. A failed ship blows up when the asteroid hits. In the few years before the last remnants of humanity die out underground, one power exerts a pathetic final superiority: The player that deployed fewer Military units to the ship in total — they have a few more laughable units left than their miserable rival.

Special Cards

A special card can be deployed on a module just like one of the three main cards. Each special card is unique with a single copy in the deck, as opposed to ten of each for the main cards.

In the Consequences phase, modules resolve from left to right, so a special card on Module 1 will always resolve before a special card on Module 2. If both players deployed a special card to a module, the card listed first below gets resolved first at that module.

Embargo

Your rival's deployment is irrelevant and does not resolve.

Salvage

Swap this card with any card you choose from the discard pile, then resolve it.

Espionage

Discard this card, deploy and resolve a different card from your hand.

Relocation

Your influence decreases by 1, but it increases by 1 in a neighboring module of your choice.

Flagship

Your influence and module development both increase by 1.

Propaganda

Your influence increases by 2.

Overtime

Module development increases by 2.

Example Gameplay

Here's an example of a module's evolution throughout the game.

Let's say our module starts out with development level 3.

Round 1. Player 1 deploys **Military (+2)**, Player 2 deploys **Colonists (+1)**. Player 1 is ahead by one, so put a token with Player 1's color next to the module die, which shows 3 on its top face.

Round 2. Player 1 deploys **Engineers (+0)**, Player 2 deploys **Military (+2)**. Now Player 2 is ahead by one, so take Player 1's token away and put one of Player 2's tokens there. Rotate the module die to show 4 on its top face — Engineers increased development by one.

Round 3. Player 1 deploys **Flagship (+1)**, Player 2 deploys **Military (+2)**. Now Player 2 is ahead by two, so add one more Player 2 token, bringing their count to two. Increase module development by one again to 5 due to Flagship. *This module is now ready for launch.*

Round 4. Player 1 deploys **Military (+2)**, Player 2 deploys **Military (+2)**. Neither side gets more influence than the other, no changes to tokens. Each military sets the development back by one level, so the module die should now show 3. *This module is no longer ready for launch.*

Round 5. Player 1 deploys **Colonists (+1)**, Player 2 deploys **Overtime (+0)**. Player 2's lead drops from 2 tokens to only 1. They are still ahead by one point, so Player 2 wins control of this module. Overtime raises development back up to 5. *The module is ready for launch at the end.*

